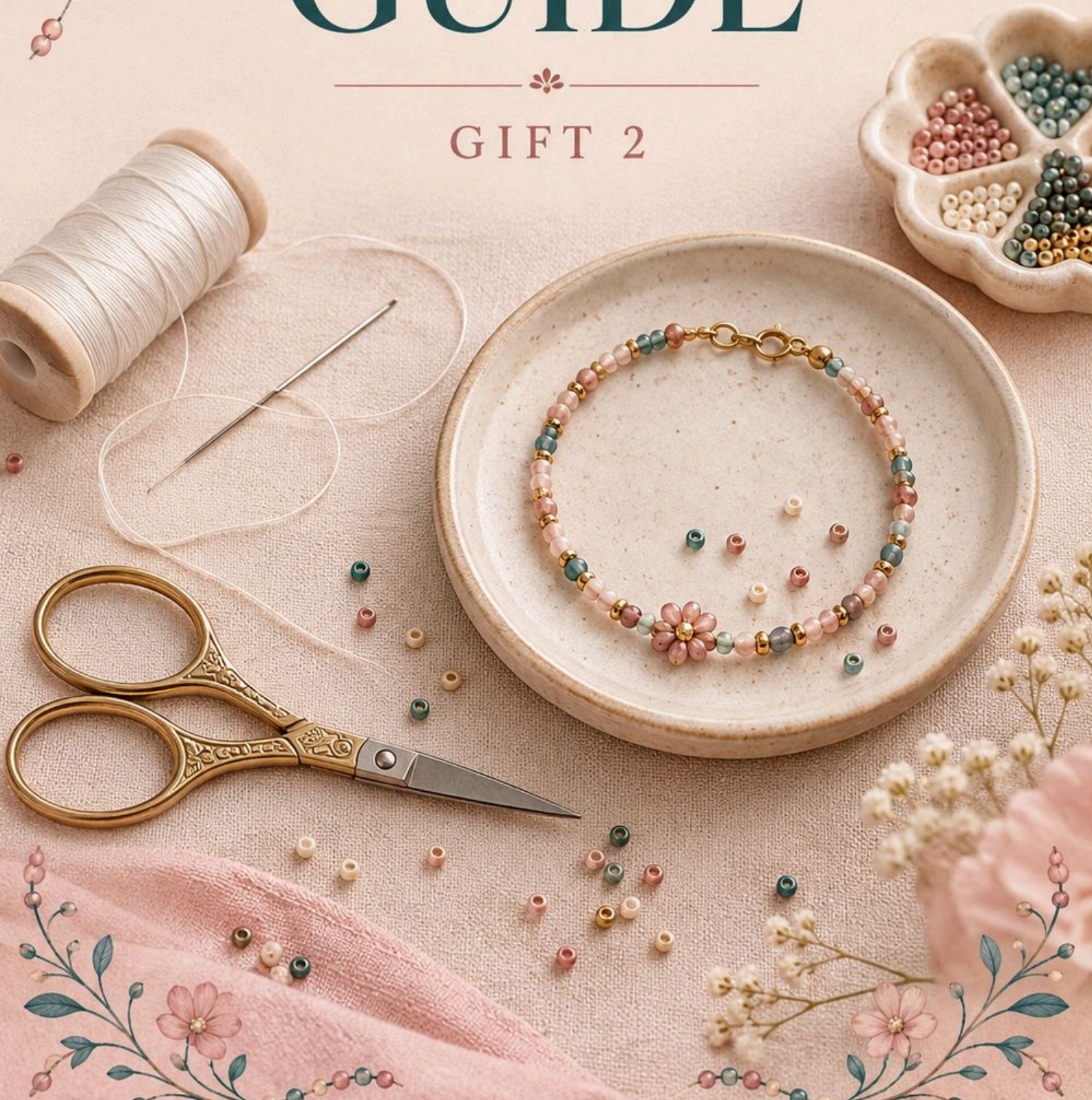
THE FIX-IT GUIDE

GIFT 2



The Fix-It Guide: 40 Common Beading Problems

Symptom, cause, fix, and prevention for the problems every beader meets

Every beader, from first-timers to experienced makers, runs into the same set of problems. Thread tangles. Rows go uneven. A clasp looks wrong. This guide gathers 40 of the most common ones and gives you a clear, calm path through each.

The entries are grouped by theme, so you can browse the section that matches what you are seeing. Each one follows the same simple structure: what you see, why it happens, how to fix it, and how to prevent it. Most fixes take minutes, and none require special equipment beyond the basics.

Mistakes are not a sign that you are bad at this. They are how the craft is learned. Keep this guide beside your bead tray and refer back to it whenever you need it.

1. Chapter 1: Thread and Tension

Most beading frustration starts with the thread. Get these five right and half your problems disappear.

> **HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE**
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> Each problem has four parts: the symptom you see, why it happens, how to fix it, and how to prevent it next time. Find your symptom, read the fix, and keep going. Almost every beading problem can be repaired, and most are caused by small habits you can change.

A useful habit for thread problems is the two-minute pause. When something feels wrong, stop stitching, set the work flat, and look at it from above. Check three things: how long your thread is, how it is twisting, and how firmly you are pulling. Nine times out of ten, the answer is in one of those three. Resist the urge to keep going and hope it will sort itself out, because tension errors grow with every row.

Thread choice matters more than most beginners expect. Size D nylon beading thread and 6 to 8 lb braided fused line are both common choices for small seed beads. Nylon is soft and drapey, while fused line is stiffer and resists fraying but can be harder to knot. Test a short sample with each before committing to a big project.

Problem 1: Thread keeps tangling and knotting

- Symptom: Thread twists into small knots as you stitch.
- Why it happens: The thread is too long, or it twists as it passes through the beads, or you pull at an angle.
- The fix: Cut a shorter length, about an arm's span or 36 to 48 inches at most. Let the needle hang and untwist every few rows. Pull straight, not sideways.
- Prevention: Work with shorter lengths and condition nylon thread lightly if it frizzes.

Problem 2: Beadwork is too tight and stiff

- Symptom: The piece feels hard, will not bend, and may buckle.
- Why it happens: You are pulling each stitch with too much force, so the beads have no room to move.
- The fix: Loosen your grip. After each stitch, pull until the thread is snug, then stop. If a section is already tight, remove it and redo it with a lighter pull.
- Prevention: Check flexibility every few rows by bending the work gently.

Problem 3: Beadwork is too loose and floppy

- Symptom: Thread shows between beads and the work looks gappy.
- Why it happens: The stitches are not pulled snug enough, or the thread is too thin for the beads.
- The fix: Take out the loose rows. Re-stitch with slightly more tension, and consider a thicker thread such as size D nylon or a 6 lb braided line.
- Prevention: Pull each stitch the same amount and match your thread to your bead size.

1. Chapter 1: Thread and Tension (continued)

- Symptom: Some rows feel firm and others feel slack.
- Why it happens: Your grip changes when you are tired, distracted, or changing hands.
- The fix: Work in short sessions. If you notice a change, stop, shake out your hands, and reset your grip before continuing.
- Prevention: Place a clip or tension bead to keep a steady hold on your work.

Problem 5: Thread frays or splits

- Symptom: The strands fuzz out or pull apart as you work.
- Why it happens: The thread is rubbing against sharp bead holes or old, dry thread is being reused.
- The fix: Replace the thread. Check for rough or chipped beads and discard them. Run thread through a bit of beeswax or thread conditioner if the type allows it.
- Prevention: Store thread away from sunlight and moisture, and avoid dragging it over rough surfaces.

2. Chapter 2: Needles and Breaking

Needles and breakage cause stress, but nearly every case has a simple cause.

If you are breaking needles often, look at your hands as well as your tools. Pulling the needle out of a bead at a sharp angle is a classic cause. Hold the bead gently with your other hand, support the work, and draw the needle out in line with the hole. Slow, straight movements protect your needles and your thread.

Keep a small needle case with three or four sizes. A size 11 is sturdy and good for larger beads. A size 12 or 13 is better for Delica 11/0 and 15/0 beads when you are making many thread passes. Having the right needle on hand turns a frustrating moment into a quick swap.

Problem 6: Needle will not fit through the bead

- Symptom: The needle sticks, especially after several passes.
- Why it happens: The needle is too thick for the bead hole, or the hole is already crowded with thread.
- The fix: Switch to a thinner beading needle in size 12 or 13. For tight spots, try a size 13 or a thin wire needle.
- Prevention: Pick a needle that matches your bead size and check the hole before you start a project.

Problem 7: Needle bends or breaks

- Symptom: The needle snaps or curves as you pull.
- Why it happens: You may be forcing it through a tight bead, or the needle is old and fatigued.
- The fix: Stop forcing. Gently work the needle or pull it through with your fingertips. Replace bent needles; do not try to straighten them.
- Prevention: Keep spare needles handy and avoid pulling the needle at an angle.

Problem 8: Thread keeps slipping out of the needle

- Symptom: The needle unthreads itself while you work.
- Why it happens: The thread end is frayed, the eye is too large for the thread, or the tail is too short.
- The fix: Cut the thread end cleanly at an angle. Leave a small tail through the eye and re-thread. A smaller needle can also hold the thread better.
- Prevention: Always trim the end with sharp scissors before threading.

Problem 9: Thread snaps mid-project

- Symptom: The thread breaks, often at a bead hole.
- Why it happens: The thread is old or too thin, or a sharp bead edge cut it.
- The fix: Add a new thread by weaving the tail through several beads, making small half-hitch knots. Replace damaged beads with smooth ones.
- Prevention: Test-pull your thread before starting and use beads that are smooth inside.

2. Chapter 2: Needles and Breaking (continued)

- Symptom: The piece falls apart or a section comes undone after wear.
- Why it happens: The thread was too weak, not enough passes were made, or the ends were not secured.
- The fix: Restring or repair with a stronger thread. Weave in tails through at least four to six beads and add half-hitch knots before trimming.
- Prevention: Reinforce high-stress points with a second pass of thread and use strong thread for jewelry that will be worn.

3. Chapter 3: Uneven Rows

Even rows come from consistent beads, consistent thread, and a calm pace.

Even rows are a matter of consistency, not perfection. Slight irregularities are part of the charm of handmade work, and most people will never notice them. Aim for rows that look tidy at arm's length and feel smooth under your fingertip. If you can accept small variations, you will enjoy the craft much more.

If you often fight uneven rows, try switching to Delica 11/0 cylinders. Their consistent shape and large holes make them forgiving for flat peyote, brick, and loom work, and many patterns are designed around them.

Problem 11: Rows are uneven in height

- Symptom: Some rows sit higher or lower, and the edge looks jagged.
- Why it happens: Beads vary in size, or you are skipping a bead or adding the wrong count.
- The fix: Remove the uneven section. Check your beads and recount each row. Use a single bead brand and size for the project.
- Prevention: Sort beads before starting and count every row as you go.

Problem 12: Edges are ragged or zigzag

- Symptom: The sides do not line up in a straight line.
- Why it happens: Stitch tension differs along the edge, or you are turning the work too loosely.
- The fix: Pull the turn stitch a bit snugger and check each edge after finishing a row. Pinch and align the beads with your fingers.
- Prevention: Keep the same tension on your turns and look at your edges every few rows.

Problem 13: Gaps between rows

- Symptom: You can see thread between rows.
- Why it happens: The thread is slack or a row was not pulled snug before moving on.
- The fix: Go back through the previous row, pull the thread until the beads touch, and then carry on. If the gaps persist, rebuild that section.
- Prevention: Snug each row as you finish it, rather than waiting until the end.

Problem 14: Beads sit crooked or slanted

- Symptom: Individual beads tilt instead of lying flat.
- Why it happens: They were not seated properly, or round beads are being mixed with cylinder beads.
- The fix: Use your thumbnail to nudge each bead into place and pull the thread. Do not mix round seed beads with Delica cylinders in the same row unless the pattern calls for it.
- Prevention: Match bead types to your stitch and keep your thread path tidy.

Problem 15: Pattern looks distorted or stretched

3. Chapter 3: Uneven Rows (continued)

- Symptom: The design appears wider or narrower than expected.
- Why it happens: Round seed beads and Delica cylinders create different aspect ratios, and some stitches stretch a pattern.
- The fix: Check that the pattern is written for the bead type you are using. Delica 11/0 cylinders sit more squarely, which helps for graphed patterns.
- Prevention: Read the pattern notes for bead size and stitch type before ordering beads.

4. Chapter 4: Wavy and Curled Work

Curling and waves usually come from tension or stitch structure, not talent.

Curling and waves are often shaped by the structure of the stitch as well as your tension. Peyote tends to have a slight curve in a long strip, while loom work lies flat more easily. Notice which stitches give you the most trouble and choose designs that fit your style.

A little gentle shaping after the piece is finished can make a big difference. Lay the beadwork face down on a soft towel, press lightly with a barely damp cloth, and let it dry flat. Always test on a small, hidden area first, because some finishes and threads react to moisture and heat.

Problem 16: Piece curls at the edges

- Symptom: The beadwork rolls up like a scroll.
- Why it happens: Tension is tighter on one side, or the stitch naturally curves, as with some peyote variations.
- The fix: Loosen the tight side. If curling is slight, steam or gentle pressing with a damp cloth can help; check the beads and thread first. Add a backing or a stiffening layer if the design calls for it.
- Prevention: Keep tension even and plan to line or back wide pieces.

Problem 17: Piece waves like a ripple

- Symptom: The surface rises and falls instead of lying flat.
- Why it happens: A mix of loose and tight rows, or decreases and increases are uneven.
- The fix: Rework the area with consistent pulls. Lay the piece on a flat surface while working to check how it sits.
- Prevention: Lay your work flat every few rows and check for rippling early.

Problem 18: Bracelet will not wrap around the wrist smoothly

- Symptom: It looks stiff or buckles on one side.
- Why it happens: The width is too wide for the stitch, or the tension is too tight.
- The fix: Loosen your tension a little and consider a narrower design. Leave enough give in the clasp area.
- Prevention: Test a short sample strip before making a full bracelet.

Problem 19: Cuff twists when worn

- Symptom: The piece rotates around the wrist.
- Why it happens: The weight is unbalanced, or the structure is too flexible.
- The fix: Add a bead or small charm on the heavier side, or stiffen the piece with a second pass of thread through the center.
- Prevention: Balance the design visually and test it on a wrist before finishing.

Problem 20: Piece is shaped like a banana

4. Chapter 4: Wavy and Curled Work (continued)

- Symptom: The finished piece bows in one direction.
- Why it happens: One edge has more stitches or tighter tension than the other.
- The fix: Loosen the shorter side or lightly stretch the beadwork. If it is badly bowed, unpick the last rows and rework them.
- Prevention: Count both edges and keep your pull consistent.

5. Chapter 5: Bead Selection and Size Mismatch

The right beads make a pattern easy. The wrong ones cause problems that look like technique errors.

Beads from different bags, or even different batches, may not match exactly. Even small differences add up over a long row. When a project depends on a precise count, buy all your beads from the same lot and keep them in separate, labeled containers.

If you are unsure about a substitution, make a small test strip. Stitch ten rows with your own beads and measure the width and height against the pattern. This tiny step can save hours of rework.

Problem 21: Beads do not fit the pattern

- Symptom: The piece ends up larger or smaller than the pattern suggests.
- Why it happens: The bead size differs from what the pattern uses. For example, Delica 11/0 is about 1.6 mm, round 11/0 is about 2 mm, and 15/0 is about 1.5 mm.
- The fix: Check the pattern's bead size and type. If you must substitute, calculate how many beads fit per inch and adjust the count.
- Prevention: Read the materials list and measure a short row with a ruler before buying more.

Problem 22: Some beads are noticeably bigger or smaller

- Symptom: Uneven bead sizes make rows look wavy.
- Why it happens: Round seed beads vary naturally and some brands are less uniform than others.
- The fix: Sort the beads through a small sieve or by eye. Set aside outliers for another project. Delica cylinders are generally more uniform.
- Prevention: Buy from a reputable seller and sort before beading.

Problem 23: Colors look different when finished

- Symptom: The piece appears duller or brighter than expected.
- Why it happens: Finishes such as matte, metallic, or opaque change under different lighting. Online photos may not match real life.
- The fix: Test colors in daylight and under household lamps before committing. Order a small sample of key colors first.
- Prevention: Keep a color notebook with bead samples and your notes on how they look.

Problem 24: Beads are chipped or have rough holes

- Symptom: Thread snags or fray.
- Why it happens: Some beads have rough or irregular holes.
- The fix: Discard chipped beads or set them aside for decoration. Test each bead by running the needle through it before use.
- Prevention: Inspect beads when they arrive and keep them in small labeled containers.

Problem 25: Thread is too thick for small beads

5. Chapter 5: Bead Selection and Size Mismatch (continued)

- Symptom: The thread will not pass through repeatedly.
- Why it happens: The thread diameter is larger than the bead hole can handle after several passes.
- The fix: Switch to a thinner nylon thread or fused line and use a smaller needle. Reduce the number of passes in tight areas.
- Prevention: Match your thread size to your bead size and test with a few beads first.

6. Chapter 6: Patterns and Counting Errors

Mistakes in patterns happen to everyone. A few habits will help you catch them early.

A good habit with any pattern is to read it twice before you start. The first time, look at the overall shape and colors. The second time, read the notes on bead type, stitch, and starting point. Many errors come from skipping this step.

Use small tools to protect your place. A ruler, a sticky note, a magnetic board, or a highlighter strip can keep your eyes on the correct row. Pause after each row and compare your work with the chart before moving on.

Problem 26: Lost count in the middle of a row

- Symptom: You are not sure whether you added the correct number of beads.
- Why it happens: Distraction or a long row without markers.
- The fix: Count beads along the row. If the count is off, remove back to the last correct section.
- Prevention: Use a pencil to mark progress on the chart and count at the end of each row.

Problem 27: Pattern does not line up

- Symptom: Motifs do not match or are shifted.
- Why it happens: A bead was skipped or added, or you misread the chart.
- The fix: Compare your work with the chart row by row. Pinpoint the first mistake and unpick to that row.
- Prevention: Cover the rows you have completed with a ruler or sticky note so you read only the next row.

Problem 28: Reading the chart upside down or reversed

- Symptom: The finished design is mirrored.
- Why it happens: Charts are read in a certain direction depending on the stitch, and some are read from the bottom.
- The fix: Check the instructions for reading direction. If you have already stitched a mirrored design, it may still look good, or you can start over.
- Prevention: Mark the starting corner and read direction clearly on the chart.

Problem 29: Odd or even count confusion in peyote

- Symptom: The piece does not turn properly at the end of a row.
- Why it happens: Even-count peyote and odd-count peyote have different turn techniques.
- The fix: Check whether your pattern uses an even or odd count. If odd, use the recommended technique for the turn, and take your time.
- Prevention: Choose even-count peyote when you are new, and learn odd-count later.

Problem 30: Added or skipped a color

6. Chapter 6: Patterns and Counting Errors (continued)

- Symptom: A pattern color is wrong in a few places.
- Why it happens: Similar colors in your tray got mixed up.
- The fix: If the mistake is small, you can sometimes carefully replace the bead by cutting it out and rethreading. Otherwise, unpick to the mistake.
- Prevention: Label your bead tubes and lay out colors in the order of the chart.

7. Chapter 7: Findings and Finishing

A beautiful piece can be ruined by a weak finish. Take a few extra minutes here.

Findings are the small metal parts that connect and finish your piece. They are also where jewelry most often fails. Take a moment to check each one: the clasp should open and close easily, jump rings should be closed flush, and ear wires should be clean and straight.

Tools help. A pair of flat-nose pliers and a pair of round-nose pliers make closing rings and shaping loops much easier. Using your fingers or the wrong tools can scratch metal and weaken the connection.

Problem 31: Clasp does not fit the piece

- Symptom: The clasp looks too large or small.
- Why it happens: The width of the beadwork does not match the clasp.
- The fix: Use a clasp that matches the width, or add a connector. Check that the loops are closed and aligned.
- Prevention: Choose your clasp before you start so you can plan the width.

Problem 32: Jump rings open or come undone

- Symptom: The ring opens slightly and the piece falls off.
- Why it happens: The ring was not closed properly or is too thin.
- The fix: Use two pairs of pliers. Open the ring sideways, never pulled apart, and close it so the ends meet flush. Use thicker rings for heavy pieces.
- Prevention: Check each ring after closing it and use a slightly heavier gauge.

Problem 33: Ear wires are crooked or uncomfortable

- Symptom: One earring hangs differently from the other.
- Why it happens: The loops are not attached in the same direction.
- The fix: Open the loop, reattach it to the same side, and close it. Check that both earrings face forward.
- Prevention: Compare the pair side by side before packing.

Problem 34: Thread tails stick out

- Symptom: Small thread ends poke from the beadwork.
- Why it happens: The tail was cut too close without being hidden.
- The fix: Gently pull the tail, weave it through several beads, make a half-hitch, and then trim. A little clear nail polish or thread glue on the knot can help, but use it sparingly.
- Prevention: Always weave in tails fully.

Problem 35: Fringe or drops hang unevenly

7. Chapter 7: Findings and Finishing (continued)

- Symptom: Some strands are longer or shorter.
- Why it happens: Bead counts differ or thread tension varies.
- The fix: Compare strand lengths and adjust the count or tension. Repeat to match.
- Prevention: Count beads for each strand and keep tension steady.

8. Chapter 8: Durability and Care

A piece that survives wear is a piece people trust. Build durability in from the start.

Care instructions are part of durability. Tell customers, or remind yourself, to remove beaded jewelry before swimming, bathing, or exercising, to avoid perfume and strong cleaners, and to store pieces flat in a dry place. These simple habits extend the life of any beadwork.

If a piece does come back with damage, treat it as useful information. Where did it fail? Was the thread too thin, or the stress point unreinforced? Each repair teaches you how to build something stronger next time.

Problem 36: Beadwork frays near the clasp

- Symptom: The thread wears quickly at the connection point.
- Why it happens: This area gets the most movement and stress.
- The fix: Add extra passes of thread through the end beads and use a protective wire guardian or a crimp cover.
- Prevention: Reinforce stress points as a standard step.

Problem 37: Piece stretches over time

- Symptom: The jewelry becomes longer or looser.
- Why it happens: Soft thread stretches, or the stitch is too open.
- The fix: Replace the thread with a stronger, low-stretch type. Rebuild the piece if it is badly stretched.
- Prevention: Choose a thread with low stretch for bracelets and necklaces.

Problem 38: Beads fall off after a short time

- Symptom: A few beads come loose.
- Why it happens: The final passes were not secured, or the thread was cut by a rough bead.
- The fix: Reinforce the area with extra thread and make sure each end is knotted and hidden.
- Prevention: Do a gentle tug test before you pack a piece.

Problem 39: Colors fade or beads lose finish

- Symptom: Some finishes dull over time.
- Why it happens: Certain coatings can wear with water, sweat, and sunlight.
- The fix: Check the bead description for finish type. Store pieces away from direct sunlight and avoid perfume and lotion.
- Prevention: Tell customers how to care for the piece.

Problem 40: Piece gets damaged in storage

8. Chapter 8: Durability and Care (continued)

- Symptom: Beads snag and tangle in a drawer.
- Why it happens: Pieces are stored loose and rub together.
- The fix: Gently untangle and repair any damage. Store each piece in its own bag, box, or compartment.
- Prevention: Store flat and separate, away from moisture.

Practice task: Tug test

Take a finished piece and gently tug on the clasp, the thread ends, and the fringe. If anything shifts, reinforce it now rather than after it is worn.

Quick diagnosis table. When something looks off and you are not sure where to look, use this table to find the likely cause and the right chapter.

What you see	Likely cause	First fix	Where to read
Thread twists or knots	Thread too long, uneven pull	Shorter thread, let needle hang and untwist	Ch. 1
Needle will not pass	Needle too thick or hole crowded	Use size 12 or 13, check hole	Ch. 2
Edges jagged	Uneven beads or tension on turns	Sort beads, snug turns	Ch. 3
Edges curl or wave	Uneven tension, loose and tight rows	Loosen tight side, lay flat	Ch. 4
Piece too big or small	Different bead size from pattern	Check bead type, measure a row	Ch. 5
Pattern shifted or mirrored	Miscounted rows, wrong reading direction	Unpick to first mistake, mark start	Ch. 6
Jump ring opens	Ring pulled apart, too thin	Twist open sideways, close flush	Ch. 7
Piece stretches or fraying at clasp	Soft thread, stress at ends	Stronger thread, extra passes	Ch. 8

A CALM RULE OF THUMB

If a problem appears suddenly, check your thread, your needle, and your tension first. These three account for most issues. If it appears slowly over many rows, check your bead sizes and your counting.

Next steps

You now have 40 practical fixes at your fingertips. When something goes wrong, take a breath, look at the symptom, and work through the steps. Patience and good habits solve most problems.

Keep notes on the issues you meet most often. Over time you will spot them earlier and prevent them altogether.

Happy beading from Tiny Bead Studio.